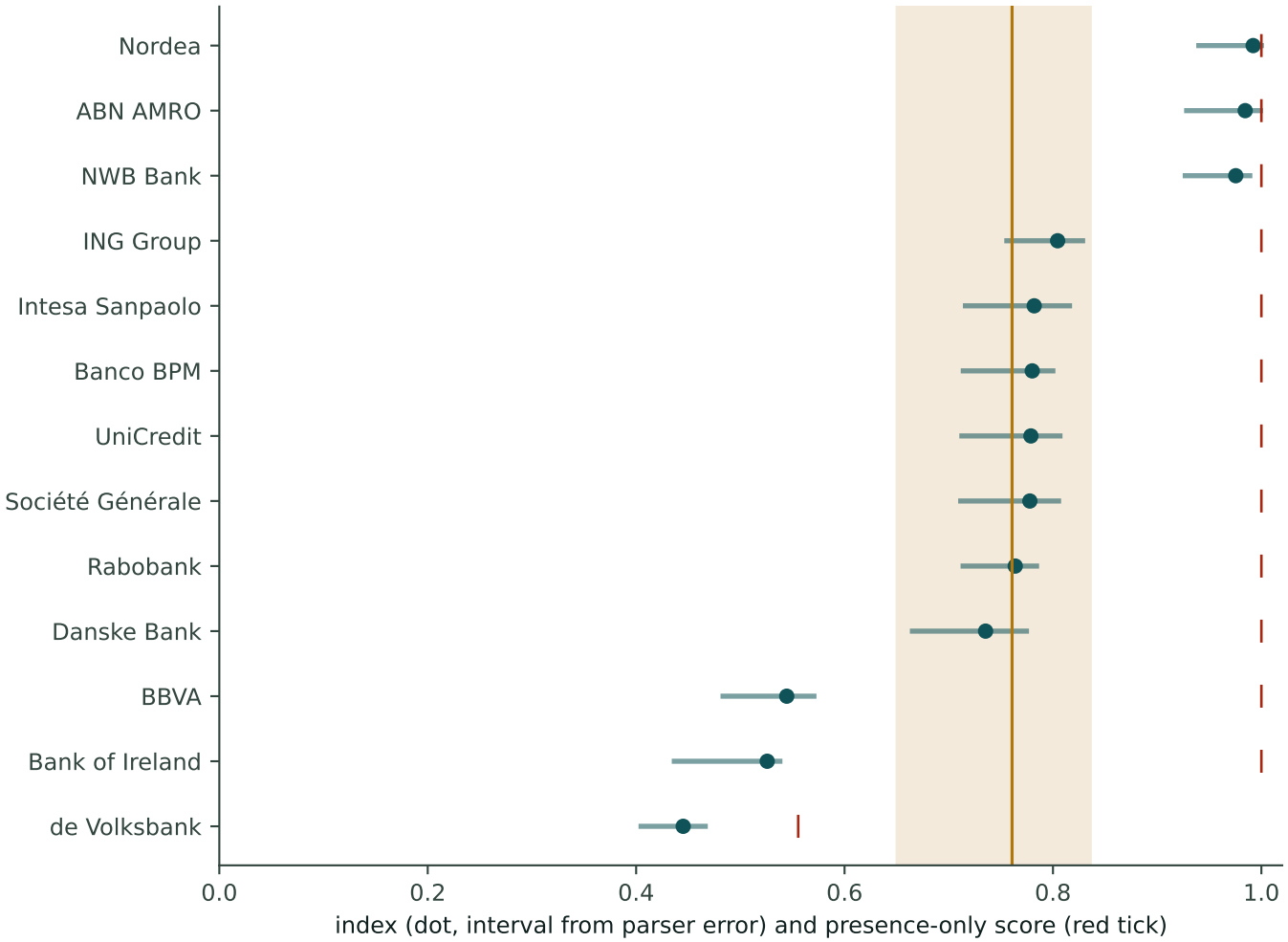
How complete are banks' Pillar 3 ESG templates?

The estimand

Per bank: the mean, over the nine mandatory EBA ESG templates (1 to 8 and 10), of the share of cells that show a value among cells that show a value or a placeholder; 0 for a template that is not in the report. Headline: the mean of that index over the banks scored.
13 banks scored; 1 of 14 listed holds no ESG template in its PDF.

The answer

Mean index 76.1%, interval [65.0%, 83.6%] (bank resampling plus parser error).
12 of 13 banks publish all nine templates; presence alone scores 96.6%.
Completeness of the cells is where banks differ: bank indices run from 44.5% (de Volksbank) to 99.2% (Nordea). Presence does not separate banks; fill does.



Method: locate, count, test the counter

Locating

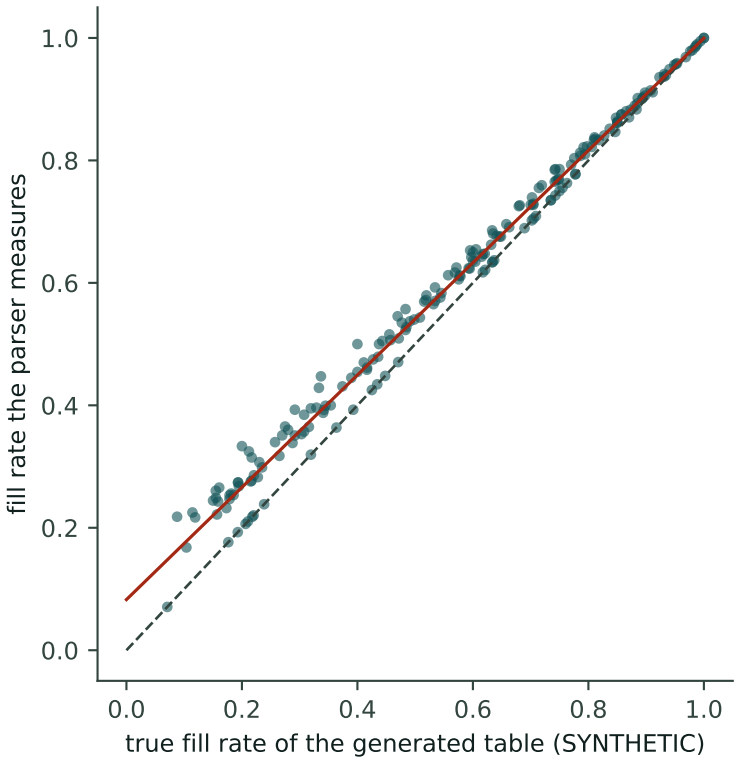
14 bank reports fetched as PDF (data/sources.csv, access date in results/fetch_log.json), text read with pypdf. A template starts at a heading line (label such as 'Template 4' or 'Tabella 4', or its full EBA title) and runs over the table pages that follow until another heading. Contents lists, prose and 'not applicable' lines are not headings. Per page, a table needs 5 cells.

Scoring

Cells are numeric tokens (years excluded) and placeholders ('-', 'n/a', 'not available'). Template score = numeric / (numeric + placeholder). Not in the report = 0. Bank index = mean of nine. A template the bank says it omits is scored 0 in the baseline and dropped in a sweep.

The parser is tested on tables with a known answer (SYNTHETIC, labelled as such)

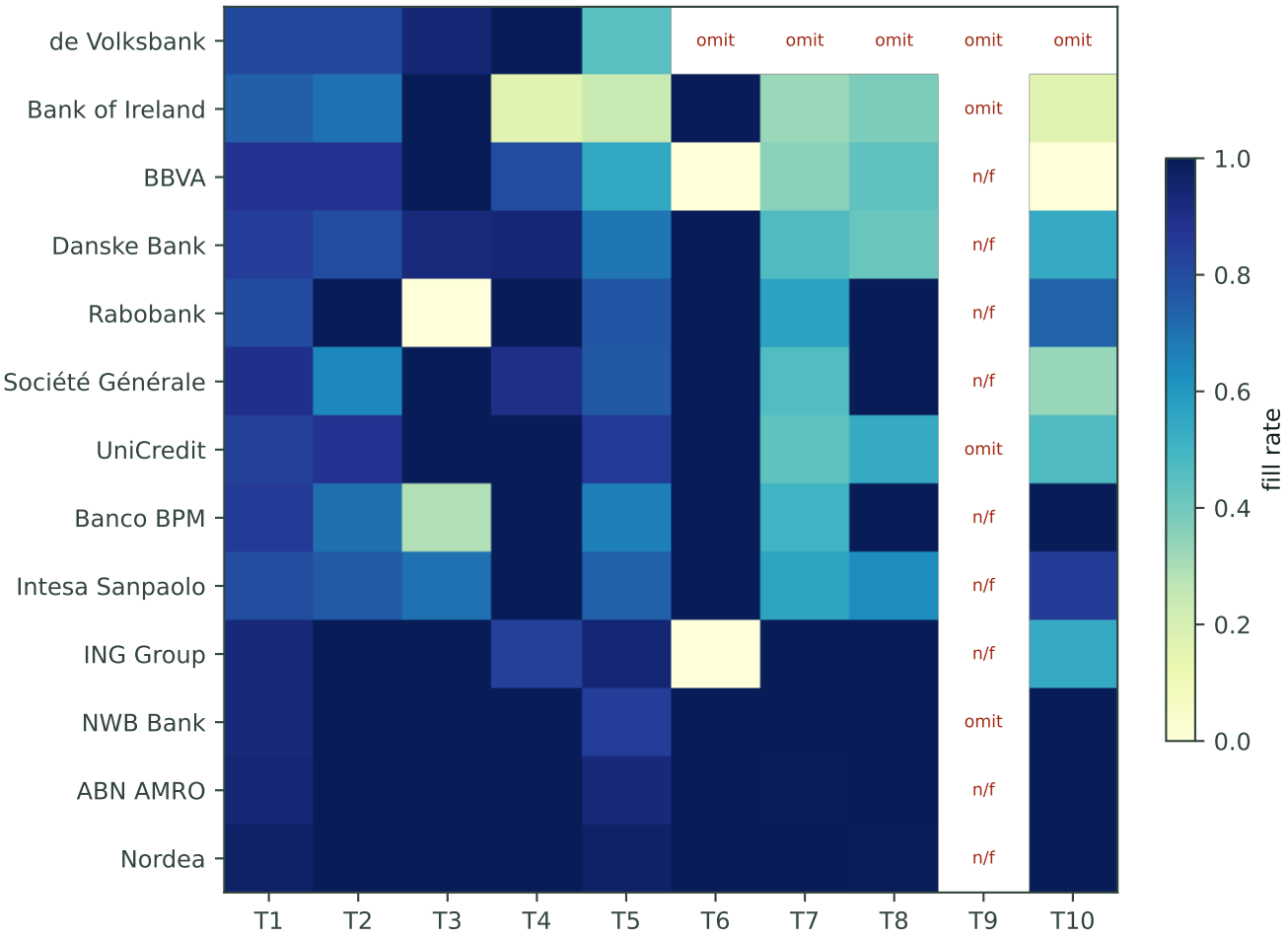
200 generated tables, five layouts, rendered to PDF and read back: mean error 3.6 points, slope 0.92, residual SD 2.3 points. The fitted line (red) corrects the index; the residual is drawn once per bank, shared by its templates, in the interval.



Result: templates are present; the cells are not all there

What the grid shows

Every bank publishes T1 to T5. T9 (BTAR) is in no report: 9 silent, 4 say so.
Lowest mean fill: T10 (63.6%); highest: T4 (89.5%). T7 reads 64.0%, T5 72.3%.
Interval parts: bank resampling alone [67.0%, 85.1%], parser error alone
[73.2%, 75.3%]. The spread between banks dominates; n=13 is small.
Parser-corrected mean: 74.5%. 'omit' = bank states omission, 'n/f' = not found.



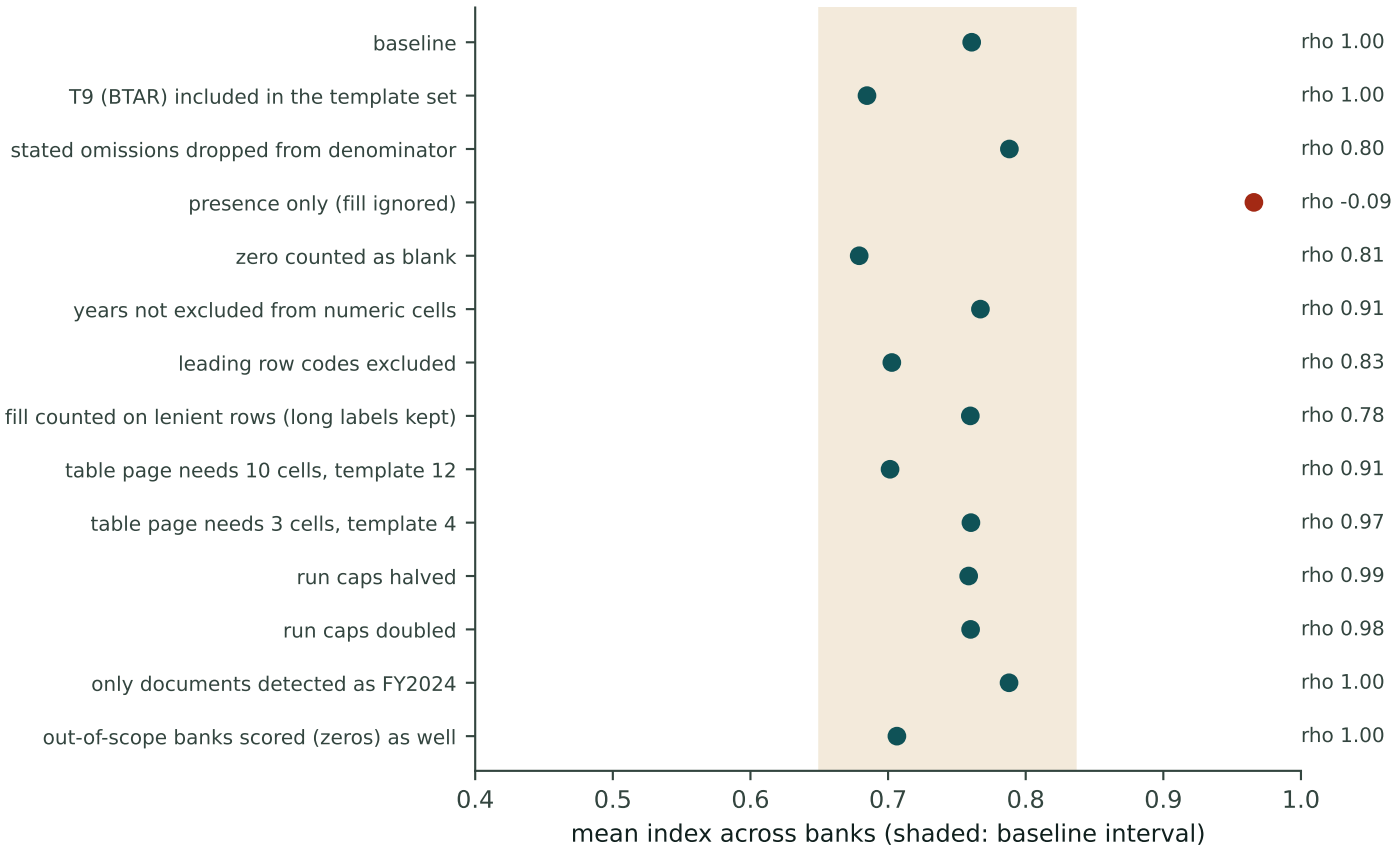
Validation and sensitivity

Validation against a source I did not fit

Banks' own contents lists print a page for each template: 34 of 37 agree with the located first page (within one page, after the bank's constant printed-to-PDF offset, estimated from the same pairs). No machine-readable second source for these cells was reached: the EBA Pillar 3 data hub is the natural one. That is a limit, not a pass: cell counts have no independent check beyond the synthetic test.

Sensitivity

Mean index ranges 67.9% (zero counted as blank) to 96.6% (presence only (fill ignored)). Excluding presence-only, the lowest rank correlation with the baseline is 0.78: the fill ranking moves with the cell definition. Presence-only has rho -0.09 with it: the two measure different things.



Limits and next step

The assumption that would break the conclusion

A blank cell leaves no token in the PDF text. The index sees placeholders, not empty cells, so a bank that leaves cells empty scores as complete. Banks scoring near 100% may simply not print a dash. The fill rate is a lower bound on incompleteness; bank-level ranks are only as good as that proxy. The test: compare against the EBA Pillar 3 data hub submission, where an empty cell is a field.

What a sceptical reviewer attacks first

Sample: 13 banks that were hand-picked in sources.csv, not a draw from euro-area banks; the interval covers banks like these, not the sector. Periods differ: two reports are FY2025, and Omnibus relief removed templates 6 to 10 for one of them. Layouts differ by bank, and the parser test covers five synthetic layouts, fewer than the real ones. Row codes and footnote digits inflate numeric counts.

Not forward-looking

The index describes one published report. It predicts nothing, so no backtest applies.

Next

Read the EBA data hub for the same banks, score empty fields, and compare with this proxy.